



The Structure of the Early Church

A SPIRIT-EMPOWERED COMMUNITY ON MISSION

The early church was not an event—it was a living, growing, Spirit-led community. Acts 2:42–47 gives us a window into how the church functioned together. These biblical elements form the foundation for a healthy church today.

FOUNDATIONAL ELEMENTS OF THE EARLY CHURCH

1		APOSTLES' DOCTRINE (THE TEACHING)	They devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching. The foundation was the Word of God—taught, believed, and lived. Truth shaped their faith and guided their life together.	Acts 2:42 Acts 4:1–4 2 Tim. 3:16–17 Eph. 4:11–12
2		FELLOWSHIP (THE COMMUNITY)	They were together and had all things in common. Genuine relationships marked by love, unity, and shared life. No one walked alone.	Acts 2:42, 44–45 Acts 4:32 1 John 1:7 Eph. 4:16
3		BREAKING OF BREAD (THE COMMUNION)	They broke bread in their homes and in the temple. This included the Lord's Supper and shared meals that strengthened their bonds.	Acts 2:42, 46 Acts 20:7 1 Cor. 11:23–26
4		PRAYERS (THE CONVERSATION)	They devoted themselves to prayer. Prayer was constant, corporate, and expectant. They depended on God in every situation.	Acts 2:42 Acts 4:24–31 Phil. 4:6–7
5		GIVING & SHARING (THE GENEROSITY)	They sold possessions and gave to anyone as he had need. Generosity flowed from grace and reflected their love.	Acts 2:44–45 Acts 4:32–35 2 Cor. 8:1–4
6		DISCIPLINE & PURITY (THE PROTECTION)	The church protected its witness by addressing sin and maintaining holiness. Love and truth worked together.	Acts 5:1–11 1 Cor. 5:1–13 Matt. 18:15–17
7		WORSHIP & PRAISE (THE EXPRESSION)	They praised God with glad and sincere hearts. Worship was joyful, Spirit-filled, and focused on God.	Acts 2:47 Acts 16:25 Ps. 100:1–2
8		MISSION & WITNESS (THE OUTREACH)	The Lord added to their number daily. They shared the Gospel boldly, and God opened the door for more.	Acts 2:47 Acts 1:8 Matt. 28:18–20
9		LEADERSHIP & ORDER (THE GUIDANCE)	God appointed leaders to shepherd the flock. Leadership was servant-hearted, qualified, and accountable.	Acts 6:1–7 1 Tim. 3:1–13 Titus 1:5–9
10		DAILY LIFE TOGETHER (THE RHYTHM)	They were in the temple daily and in homes. Faith was lived out every day, everywhere. The church was both visible and relational.	Acts 2:46 Acts 5:42 Heb. 10:24–25

DAILY LIFE OF THE EARLY CHURCH (ACTS 2:42–47)



"And the Lord added to their number daily those who were being saved." Acts 2:47



THE BIG PICTURE

The early church was built on the Word, powered by the Spirit, marked by love, and sent on mission. This is God's design for His Church: a growing, worshipping, witnessing community that brings glory to Christ and hope to the world.



TEACHER NOTE

Use this chart to help learners see that the church is more than a building or a program. It is a people—called, equipped, and empowered by the Holy Spirit to live together for God's glory and the world's good.



KEY VERSES

Acts 2:42–47

"They devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and to fellowship, to the breaking of bread and to prayer. Everyone was filled with awe at the many wonders and signs performed by the apostles."

Acts 4:32–33

"All the believers were one in heart and mind. No one claimed that any of their possessions was their own, but they shared everything they had."

1 Corinthians 12:27

"Now you are the body of Christ, and each one of you is a part of it."

Ephesians 4:11–13

"He gave some to be apostles, some to be prophets, some to be evangelists, some to be pastors and teachers, to equip His people for works of service, so that the body of Christ may be built up."



KEY TRUTHS

- The early church was Spirit-led, not program-driven.
- Doctrine, fellowship, and mission worked together.
- Every believer had a place and a purpose.
- Unity was not uniformity—love held them together.
- The church existed to glorify God and reach people.



RELATED RESOURCES



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View the Early Church Structure Diagram.



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Glossary

See: Doctrine, Fellowship, Discipline, Worship, Mission, Leadership.